

Article 29
Amend Zoning Bylaws: § V-H Signage and Advertising Devices - Downtown Mixed Use (DM) and Center Gateway (CG) Zoning District
(Heather Rockwood et al)

ARTICLE LANGUAGE

To see if the Town will vote to amend the Natick Zoning Bylaws by amending § V-H Signage and Advertising Devices, 2. Downtown Mixed Use District (DM) and Center Gateway (CG) Signage; amending Section 200 - Definitions; amending § VI-K.4.d Signs and Advertising Devices; and further amend any other associated sections, where applicable; or otherwise act thereon.

PURPOSE OF THE ARTICLE

To amend the Natick Zoning Bylaws by amending § V-H Signage and Advertising Devices, 2. Downtown Mixed Use District (DM) and Center Gateway (CG) Signage; amending Section 200 - Definitions; amending § VI-K.4.d Signs and Advertising Devices; and further amend any other associated sections, where applicable; or otherwise act thereon.

FINANCE COMMITTEE RECOMMENDATION

The Finance Committee took the following action:	RECOMMENDATION:	Favorable
	QUANTUM OF VOTE:	8-5-0
	DATE VOTED:	9/30/2025

Motion

Move that the Town vote to amend the Natick Zoning Bylaw by adding new definitions for Individual Building Establishment Unit; Multi-tenant Building; Sign, Awning; Sign Box; Sign, Blade; Sign, Building Identification; Sign, Directory Wall; Sign, Establishment Window; Sign, Exterior Notification Flag; Sign, Monument; Sign, Permanent; Sign, Projecting Hanging; Sign, Public Service; Sign, Roof; Sign, Sidewalk; Sign, Temporary; and Sign, Wall-Mounted, to read as follows:

Section 200 – Definition

Individual Business Establishment Unit: A single physical unit that is leased or owned by a commercial business or organization that is used for commercial business operations.

Multi-tenant Building: A Building that contains more than one (1) Individual Business Establishment Unit.

Sign, Awning: A sign, also known as a canopy sign, located on the surface of an awning or attached above, below, or to the face of an entry canopy that identifies an Individual Business Establishment Unit or Multi-tenant Building.

Sign Box: A predetermined, dimensional area of the first-floor exterior of a Building, as approved by the Planning Board, in which a business sign must be located for an Individual Business Establishment Unit or Multi-tenant Building.

Sign, Blade: Similar to a Projecting Hanging Sign, but is a small, two-sided commercial sign that is attached to and projecting perpendicularly from the façade of a Building that identifies a commercial business located within an Individual Business Establishment Unit. Blade Signs may be stacked vertically. Information type is limited to the business name and logo.

Sign, Building Identification: A sign that provides the recognized name of a Building, complex, or center, but not the name of a commercial business, Individual Business Establishment Unit, product, or service.

Sign, Directory Wall: A sign that is located on an exterior wall, next to a publicly accessible entrance that is installed and maintained by a Multi-tenant Building owner to identify commercial businesses and their location within the Building.

Sign, Establishment Window: A sign for a commercial business or organization that is located within an Individual Business Establishment Unit and is hung inside within three (3) inches or applied to the window itself. Such signage includes the name and/or the logo of the business but shall not include the advertisement for specific products or services.

Sign, Exterior Notification Flag: A flag that notifies the public that a commercial business located within an Individual Business Establishment Unit is open or having a sale. Such flag shall be located on a pole that is no greater than four (4) feet in length, which includes the entire pole, bracket, and area where the flag is located. The pole shall be mounted to the exterior of a Building by bracket and not on the ground. Such signage shall only be displayed during hours of business operation and located as to not impede pedestrian mobility.

Sign, Monument: A low-profile freestanding sign that is distinguished from other freestanding signs by its support structure. A Monument Sign is supported primarily by an internal structural framework or integrated into a solid structural feature, such as a masonry base or landscaping, rather than being held up by exposed poles.

Sign, Permanent: A sign that is affixed to a Building, which includes the name and/or logo of a business(es) occupying an Individual Business Establishment Unit or name of the Building. Such signage does not advertise a specific product or service and does not include a phone number or website address.

Sign, Projecting Hanging: A two-sided commercial sign that is attached to and projecting perpendicularly from the façade of a Building that identifies a commercial business located within an Individual Business Establishment Unit. Information type is limited to the business name and logo.

Sign, Public Service: A sign installed for the purpose of providing public information, wayfinding, or providing directions towards an indication of use not readily visible from the street (e.g., rest rooms, emergency services, etc.) and is managed by the Town of Natick.

Sign, Roof: A sign that is erected on the roof or mounted to the uppermost horizontal architectural band of a Building to identify the name of the Building or commercial business. A Roof Sign is intended to be viewed by pedestrians and motorists from a distance and serve as an icon for the building.

Sign, Sidewalk: Also known as a sandwich board or A-frame sign, is a portable, two-sided commercial sign that is placed on the sidewalk to identify a business or advertise daily specials or sales. Sidewalk Signs are intended to be viewed at close range by pedestrians on the same side of the street.

Sign, Temporary: A sign that is removed daily.

Sign, Wall-Mounted: A sign attached flat or mounted parallel to the facade of a Building that identifies a commercial business or organizational operations open to the public.

And further vote to delete § V-H.D.2 Downtown Mixed Use District (DM) and Center Gateway District (CG) (**sign regulations**) in its entirety; and replace with a new § V-H.D.2 Downtown Mixed Use District (DM) and Center Gateway District (CG) (**sign regulations**), to read as follows:

V-H.D 2. Downtown Mixed Use District (DM) and Center Gateway District (CG) Zoning Districts

Signage in the Downtown Mixed Use (DM) and the Center Gateway (CG) Zoning Districts shall comply with the following signage regulations.

(a) Type of Signs

- i. The DM and CG Zoning Districts allow for a variety of Permanent and Temporary Signage, as outlined below.

	Sign Type	Individual Business Establishment Units			Multi-tenant Building	Non-Building Signage
		First Floor Business Establishment		Non-First Floor Business Establishment	Building Signage	Public Signage
		Frontage	Side/Rear			
P	Wall-Mounted Sign	Y	Y	N	N	N
P	Projecting Hanging Sign	Y	N	N	N	N
P	Blade Sign	Y	Y	Y	N	N
P	Establishment Window Sign	Y	Y	Y	N	N
T	Temporary Window Sign	Y	N	N	N/A	N/A
P	Awning Sign	Y	Y	SP	Y	N/A
P	Building Identification Sign	N/A	N/A	N/A	Y	N/A
P	Monument Sign	N	N	N	Y	Y
P	Directory Wall Sign	N	N	N	Y	Y
P	Roof Sign	N	N	N	N	N
T	Sidewalk Sign	Y	Y	N	Y	N
T	Exterior Notification Flag Sign	Y	N	N	N	N
P/T	Public Service Sign	N	N	N	N	Y

P = Permanent Signage

T = Temporary Signage

Y = Allowed As of Right in an approved Sign Box (Planning Board) or License (Select Board) as outlined in §V-H.2(d) of this Bylaw

SP = Special Permit (Planning Board)

N = Prohibited

(b) Sign Dimensional Regulations

- i. The dimensional area designed as a Sign Box shall be established and designed in accordance with the following standards.

Calculation For Sign Area	Sign Type	Individual Business Establishment Unit Maximum	Multi-tenant Building Maximum	Public Signage Maximum
SB	Primary Wall-Mounted Sign – Primary Frontage	30 sf (2 ft max. letter height)	N/A	N/A

SB	Secondary Wall-Mounted Sign – Secondary Frontage (Side/Rear of Business)		15 sf (1 ft max. letter height)	N/A	N/A
SB	Projecting Hanging Sign - Primary Frontage		12 sf	N/A	N/A
SB	Projecting Hanging Sign – Secondary Frontage (Side/Rear of Business)		N/A	N/A	N/A
SB	Blade Sign - Primary Frontage/Side/Rear of Business		2 sf	N/A	N/A
SB	Building Identification Sign		N/A	30 sf	
SB	Awning Sign	Located on Valance	50% coverage	50% coverage	50% coverage
		Located on Awning Slope	25% coverage	25% coverage	25% coverage
SB	Monument Sign*		N/A	20 sf	SR
SB	Exterior Directory Sign		N/A	8 sf	SR
SB	Establishment Window Sign		12 sf	50 % of total window area	N/A
TS	Temporary Window Sign		--		N/A
TS	Sidewalk Sign**		27" width x 46" height	27" width x 46" height	N/A
TS	Exterior Notification Flag Sign		12" width x 42" length	N/A	N/A
SB	Public Service Sign		N/A	N/A	SR

SB = Sign Box (size of Sign Box)

TS = Temporary Sign (dimensions include the usable advertising area, not including pole/stand/legs)

N/A = Not Applicable (sign type is not permitted)

SR = Special Review: Approval of size required by Police Department, Fire Department, Department of Public Works, Building Commissioner, and where applicable the Historic District Commission (if applicable) prior to the issuance of a Building Permit

* = A Monument Sign may be installed for a single occupant building and a Multi-Tenant Building.

** = The total area for Sidewalk Sign includes the usable sign face, legs, frame, and hardware.

ii. Permanent Signage Installation Guidance

To aid in the positioning of Permanent Signage, the following guidance shall be followed.

Sign Type	Projection from Facade (Maximum)	Distance from Ground to Bottom of Sign (Minimum)	Distance from Ground to Top of Sign (Maximum)	Spacing from top of Sign to top of building or bottom of second floor windows (Minimum)	Spacing from edge of sign to edge of Individual Business Establishment Unit (Minimum)
Wall-Mounted Sign	6 inches	10 feet	N/A	3 feet	2 feet
Projecting Hanging Sign	4 feet	8 feet	12 feet	5 feet	2 feet
Blade Sign ¹	2 feet	8 feet	20 feet	N/A	N/A
Monument Sign	N/A	N/A	4 feet	N/A	N/A
Building Identification Sign	As permitted by the Planning Board				

¹

Blade Signs may be vertically stacked upon each other. When vertically stacked the bottom of the Blade Sign closest to the ground shall be no less than eight (8) feet from the ground, and the top Blade Sign furthers from the ground shall be no more than twenty (20) feet from the ground.

(c) Signage Requirements

- Permanent Signage shall not feature interchangeable letters, internal illumination, or include movable parts (exception for Barber Poles and clocks).
- Permanent Signs are encouraged to display the Individual Business Establishment Unit street number unless provided on front door or over the main entrance. Or in cases where a sign advertises a non-first floor Individual Business Establishment Unit, the floor level where the unit is located should be provided.
- Permanent Signage shall be constructed of a material made to withstand weather elements.
- First Floor Individual Business Establishment Units Sign Requirements

- a) For Individual Business Establishment Units with multiple exterior walls and entrances, the Building Commissioner shall designate one exterior wall as the Primary Frontage, and the remaining exterior walls will be identified as the Secondary Frontage (i.e., side/rear walls).
 - 1) Primary Frontage - An Individual Business Establishment Unit may be permitted to have one (1) Primary Wall-Mounted Sign and one (1) Blade Sign; or one (1) Projecting Hanging Sign on the Primary Frontage of the Individual Business Establishment Unit.
 - 2) Secondary Frontage – An Individual Business Establishment Unit with identified secondary frontage may be permitted to have one (1) Secondary Wall-Mounted Wall Sign and one (1) Blade Sign.
 - 3) Multiple Secondary Frontages – An Individual Business Establishment Unit is permitted to have a maximum of one (1) Secondary Wall-Mounted Wall Sign and one (1) Blade Sign total
 - b) Individual Business Establishment Units shall only be permitted one (1) Sidewalk Sign or one (1) Exterior Notification Flag Sign.
 - v. Non-first Floor Individual Business Establishment Unit Sign Requirements
 - a) A non-first-floor Individual Business Establishment Unit may have a maximum of two (2) blade signs and location, as outlined below.
 - 1) A maximum of one (1) Blade Sign front or side of a Building, located either on the corner of the Building or positioned in a location that does not impede with a first floor Business Establishment; and
 - 2) A maximum of one (1) Blade Sign on the side of the building is used to access the business establishment.
 - b) Blade Signs for non-first-floor business establishments shall be stacked vertically.
 - vi. Wall-Mounted Sign
 - a) Wall-Mounted Signs are only permitted for first-floor Individual Business Establishment Units.
 - b) Wall-Mounted Signs are prohibited from covering windows or architecture details.
 - c) No portion of a Wall-Mounted Sign is permitted to extend above the lower eave line of a building with a pitched roof; extend above the roof line or parapet wall of a flat roofed building; extend above the cornice or expression line of the base of a building.
 - d) Information type is limited to business name and logo.
 - vii. Awning Sign
 - a) Awning Sign may be located on the sloping portion of an awning are only permitted for storefronts where the typical area for a wall sign is missing.
 - b) Awning Signs are not allowed on the side of awning with closed ends.
 - c) Information type is limited to business name, logo, and address.
 - viii. Sidewalk Sign
 - a) One (1) Sidewalk Sign is permitted per first floor Individual Business Establishment Unit; or for use by non-first floor Individual Business Establishment Units, the owner of the Multi-Business Building is permitted to have one (1) Sidewalk Sign per publicly accessible entrance or one (1) per side of the Multi-tenant Building, whichever is less.
 - b) Sidewalk signs may be placed outdoors on-site or on a public sidewalk during business hours and must be removed when the business is closed.
 - c) Sidewalks signs displayed on a public sidewalk shall be placed in compliance with American Disabilities Act (ADA).

- d) A sidewalk sign is not permitted to be illuminated or contain any electronic components.
- ix. Monument Sign
 - a) Only one (1) Monument Sign shall be permitted for a Building, complex, or center.
 - b) The structure of a Monument Sign shall consist of brick or masonry construction, complete with adequate footing.
 - c) The maximum height of a Monument Sign shall not exceed four (4) feet to the top of the sign above the ground
 - d) A Monument Sign shall be located a minimum of ten (10) feet from all property lines, and where deemed necessary by the Building Commissioner or the Planning Board, the setback shall be increased so that the sign and associated landscaping does not obstruct views from or onto other properties or site distance of a driver of oncoming, intersecting, or merging traffic.
 - e) All Monument Signs shall be landscaped with well-maintained plantings ten (10) feet around the entire base of the sign.
 - f) Monument Signs are prohibited in the Downtown Mixed Use (DM) Zoning District.

(d) Sign Maintenance

- a) All commercial signs, including existing nonconforming signs, together with any supports, braces, anchors, and other supporting hardware, must be maintained in good condition.
- b) Damage to or deterioration of a commercial sign must be repaired within thirty (30) days of receipt of notice from the Building Commissioner/Sign Officer.
- c) When an existing commercial sign is removed, replaced, or repaired, all supports, braces, anchors, and other supporting hardware that is no longer necessary must be removed and any surfaces baring evidence of prior attachment must be repaired.

(e) Permitting Procedures

i. Permanent Signage

a) Sign Box Permitting

- 1) The Sign Box is a permitted location that holds a Permanent Sign that is approved by the Planning Board by a simple majority vote.
- 2) Modifications that increase the size, modify the shape, or modify the location of an approved Sign Box, but proposed new Sign Box complies with § V.H.2 of this Bylaw shall require a new review and approval by the Planning Board.
- 3) A Sign Box that requires dimensional relief or deviation of its location from § V-H.2 of this Bylaw shall require a Special Permit from the Planning Board. The Design Review Board (DRB) shall provide a letter of comment to the Planning Board for such Special Permit.

b) Established Sign Box Dimensions and Locations

- 1) Permanent Signs that are placed within an approved Sign Box require a Building Permit.
- 2) Changes to the content of a Permanent Sign that complies with an approved Sign Box shall require a new Building Permit before installation.

ii. Temporary Signage

- a) The Select Board shall license Temporary Signage annually.
- b) A license shall include but is not limited to the location where a Temporary Sign can be located, requirements for use of a Temporary Sign, in addition to maintenance of condition of the Temporary Sign.

iii. Public Signage

- a) The Select Board shall be the approval granting authority for all Public Service Signs and Directory Signs that are installed within the public right of way or on Town property for the purposes of wayfinding.
- b) Prior to review by the Select Board, the dimensions and location of Public Service Signs and Directory Signs shall be reviewed by the Police Department, Fire Department, Department of Public Works, and the Building Commissioner to ensure that the signage does not compromise public safety and circulation.
- c) Design associated with public wayfinding shall be developed through an open, public process.